Viewer Retention in OTT Platforms

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Challenges and Objectives

Challenges

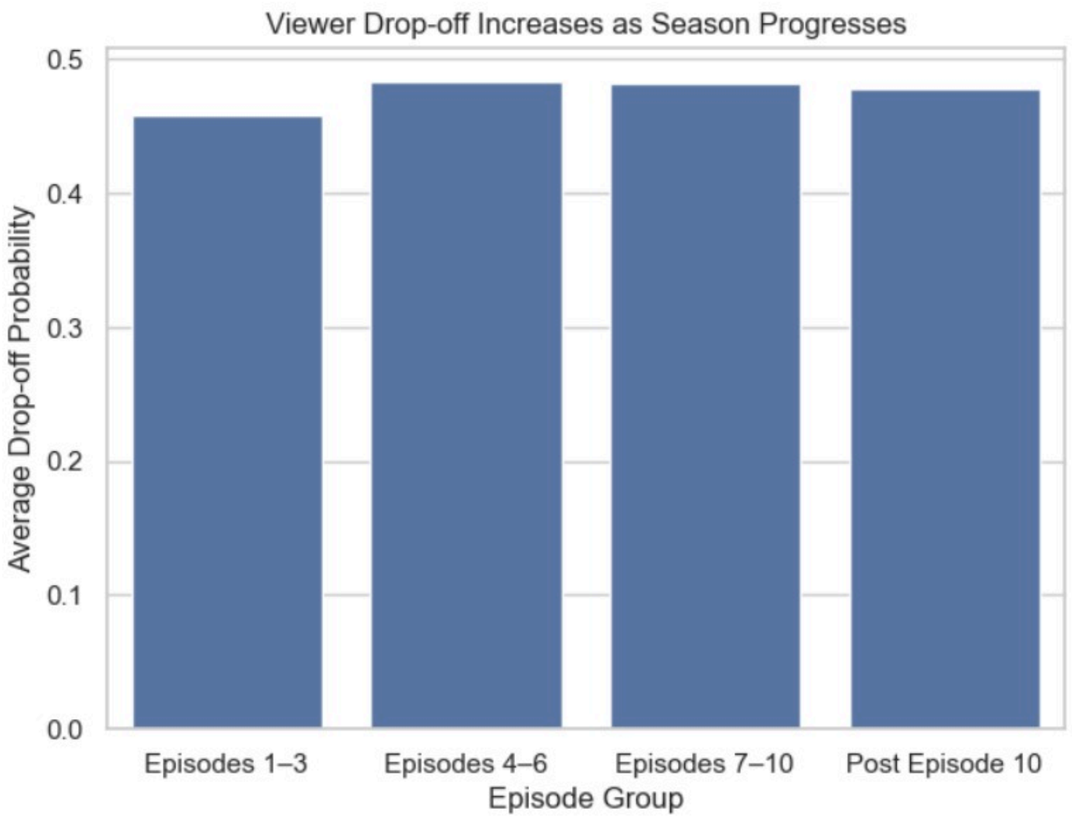
- High early drop-off observed across multiple episodes, limiting overall series completion
- Uneven engagement between episodes within the same series, despite similar promotion
- Unclear drivers of viewer continuation across content design and viewing behavior
- Lack of segmentation, making targeted retention interventions difficult.

Objectives

- Identify key factors driving episode-level viewer continuation and drop-off
- Analyze viewer behavior patterns linked to higher or lower engagement
- Segment episodes based on content and behavioral characteristics
- Design data-backed actions to improve retention and episode completion

Problem Diagnosis

Drop-off by Episode Bucket



Early-Season Viewer Drop-off Limits Lifetime Value

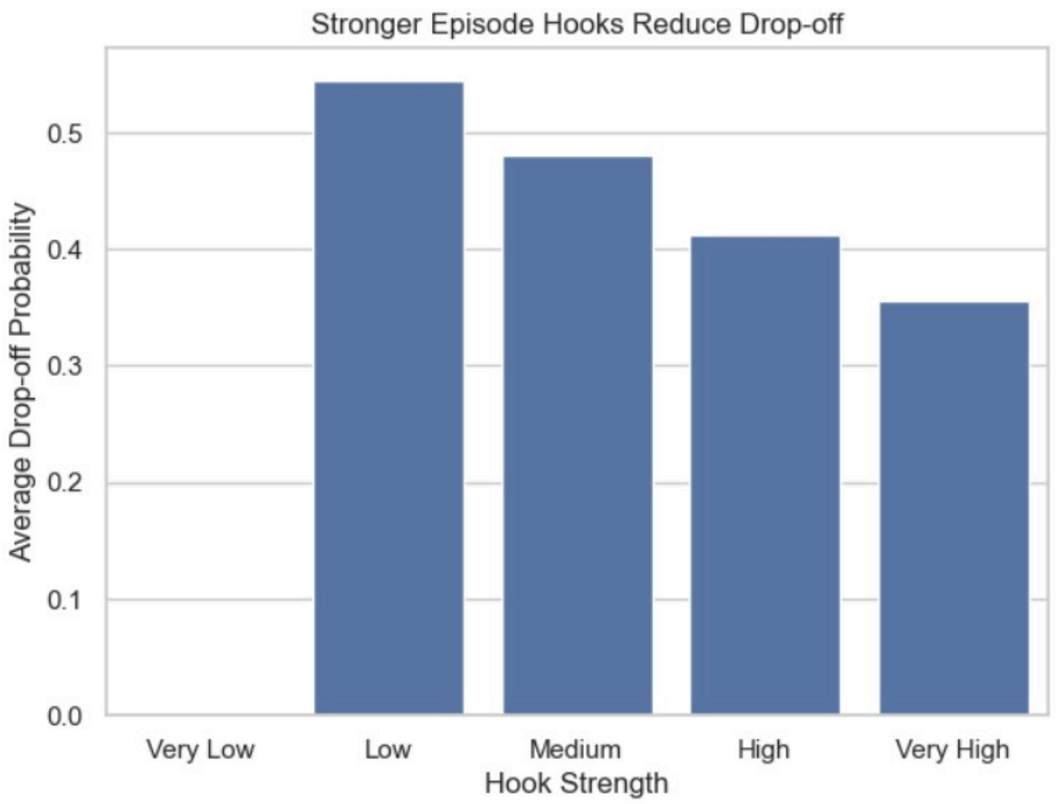
- Strong launch viewership but steep drop-off within Season 1
- Disengagement accelerates after initial episodes
- Early exit constrains renewal decisions and LTV

Key Drivers of Drop-off

Episode-Level Design Choices Drive Retention Outcomes

- Weak opening hooks are a primary cause of early disengagement
- Strong hooks materially reduce drop-off probability
- Early narrative investment is critical

Hook Strength vs Drop-off

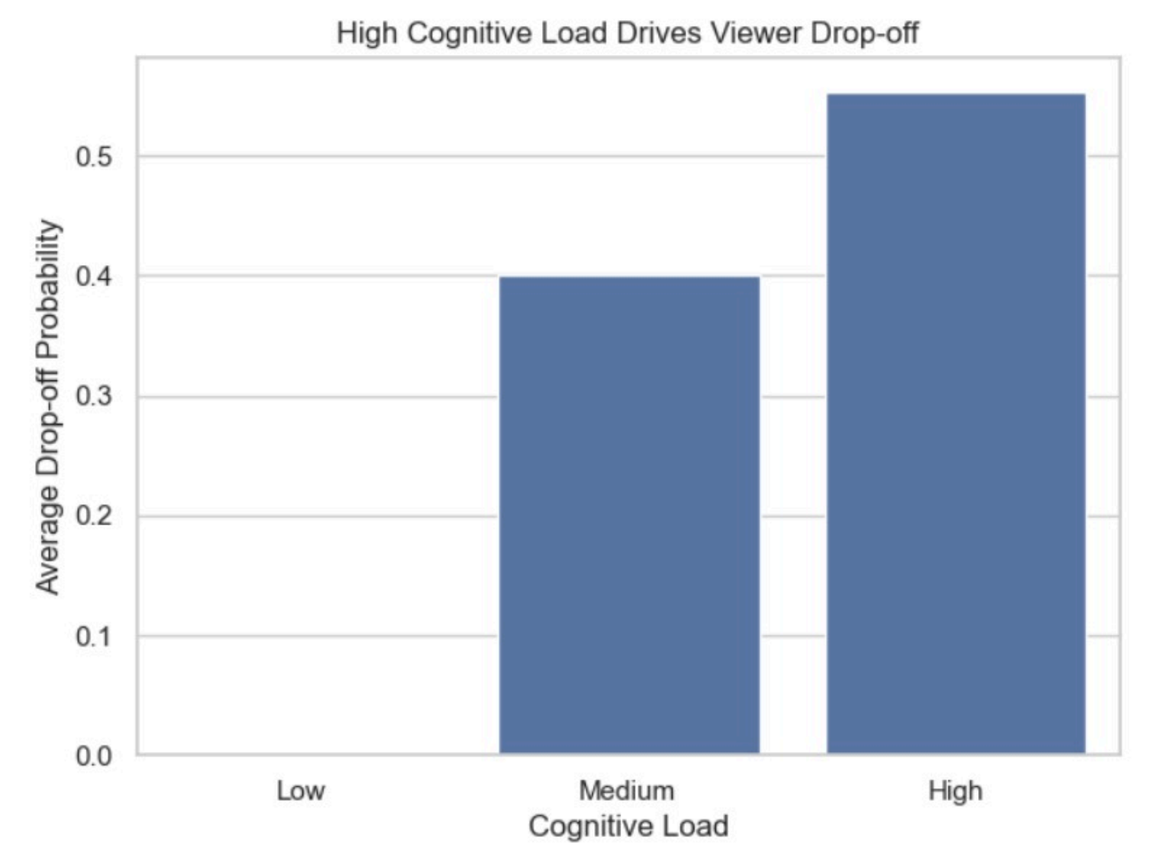


Cognitive Load vs Drop-off

Content Design Diagnosis

Cognitive Overload Accelerates Viewer Exit

- High cognitive load increases viewer fatigue
- Viewers disengage when narrative complexity spikes early
- Simplification improves continuity without harming depth

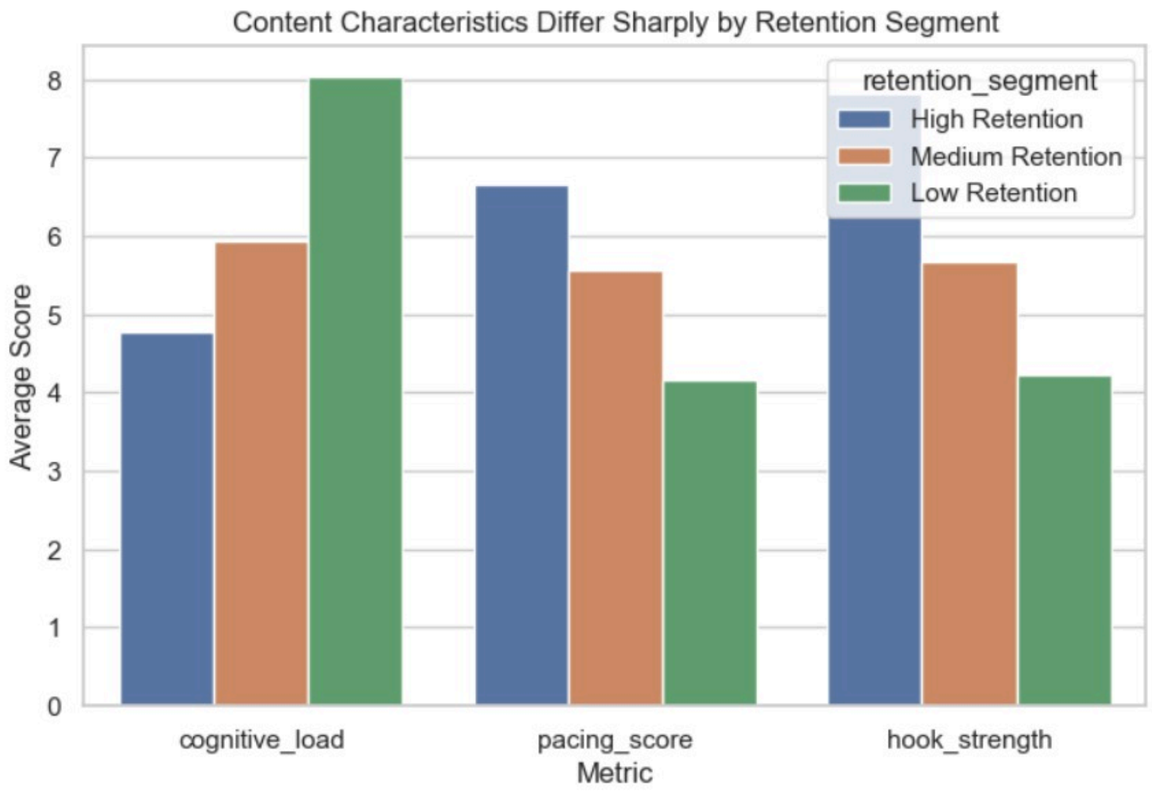


Segmentation

Retention Segment Profile

Episodes Segment into Distinct Retention Archetypes

- High-retention episodes balance hook strength and pacing
- Low-retention episodes combine weak hooks and high cognitive load
- Not all content requires the same design strategy



Recommendations

Targeted Content and Product Interventions Can Reduce Drop-off

Strengthen episode openings (recap + early narrative hook)

Manage cognitive load in Episodes 1–3

Improve pacing consistency across episodes

Introduce contextual nudges for complex episodes

Prioritization

Focus on High-Impact, Low-Risk Interventions First

01

Priority 1 (Immediate): Hook strengthening in early episodes

02

Priority 2 (Short-term): Cognitive load smoothing

03

Deprioritized: Blanket creative changes across all content

Risks & Metrics

Clear Metrics and Guardrails Ensure Creative Integrity

Metrics	Risks & Mitigation
• Episode-level drop-off probability • Season-1 completion rate • Continued-to-next-episode rate	• Creative dilution → controlled A/B testing • Viewer fatigue → targeted, not uniform changes

Thank you

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